

Ambystoma mexicanum

Axolotl



Location Mexico (Lake Xochimilco)

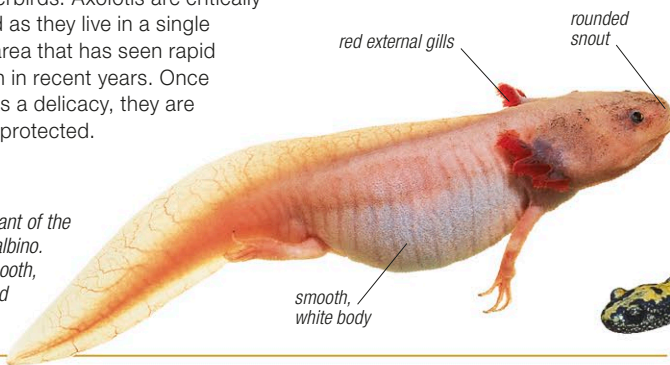
Length 4–8 in (10–20 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding season Summer
Status Critically endangered



This plump amphibian is a classic example of neoteny, or the ability to breed without ever developing a fully adult body. It has a flattened tail and large external gills—features that most salamanders lose when they become mature and take up life on land. Largely nocturnal, the axolotl feeds mainly on invertebrates, and is preyed upon in turn by waterbirds. Axolotls are critically endangered as they live in a single lake, in an area that has seen rapid urbanization in recent years. Once esteemed as a delicacy, they are now legally protected.

ALBINO

One color variant of the axolotl is the albino. This has a smooth, white body and red gills.



CAPTIVE FORMS



Typically black in the wild, many color variants of the axolotl have been bred in captivity. They may be albinos (white with red gills), gray, or mottled black and white. This species is more commonly seen in captivity than in the wild. If the captive animals are injected with a thyroid hormone, they lose their gills and become terrestrial.

Plethodon glutinosus

Slimy salamander



Location E. USA

Length 4½–8 in (11.5–20 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding season Variable
Status Least concern



This large, slender-bodied salamander gets its name from the glue-like slime that it exudes when handled. The

slime is extremely sticky—taking several days to wash off—and it gives the salamander highly effective protection against most predators. Adults are dark blue or black, with many small silver or gold spots. In the breeding season, males develop a swollen vent (cloaca) and a large gland under the chin. The slimy salamander is nocturnal, living in wooded hillsides and ravines.



Plethodon cinereus

Red-backed salamander



Location S.E. Canada, C. and E. USA

Length 2½–5 in (6.5–12.5 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding season Fall to early spring
Status Least concern



This small salamander is dark gray or brown, usually with a broad red or red-brown stripe along its body and tail. Males use feces to mark their territory

and to attract females. In the breeding season, females inspect the droppings, preferring to mate with males that have eaten a lot of termites. Males can reproduce every year, but females are fertile only in alternate years. The eggs are attached to the roofs of underground chambers.



Ambystoma macrodactylum

Long-toed salamander



Location S.W. Canada, N.W. USA

Length 4–6½ in (10–17 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Fall and spring
Status Least concern



The long-toed salamander is found in a wide variety of terrestrial habitats, where it spends much of its time underground. However, in spring, large numbers of this nocturnal species migrate to ponds to breed. It has a slender gray or black body, with a yellow, tan, or green dorsal stripe or blotches on the body. When attacked, it coils its body and lifts its tail in the air. Numbers have reduced because of habitat loss and the introduction of fish, that eat the larvae, to its breeding areas.



Plethodon jordani

Jordan's salamander



Location E. USA (Southern Appalachian Mountains)

Length 3¼–7½ in (8.5–18.5 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding season Summer and fall
Status Near threatened



Also known as the red-cheeked salamander, this nocturnal species has a long, slender body and tail, a large head with prominent eyes and, typically, red patches on its legs or cheeks, although this characteristic varies considerably between subspecies. Both males and females are territorial. If threatened, this salamander produces a distasteful slimy secretion from its tail, and may shed its tail if attacked. It mainly feeds on millipedes, beetles, and insect larvae. The male breeds every year, while the female breeds only in alternate years.



Desmognathus ochrophaeus

Mountain dusky salamander



Location E. USA

Length 2¾–4¼ in (7–11 cm)
Habit Wholly terrestrial
Breeding season Spring, summer, and fall
Status Least concern



The mountain dusky salamander belongs to a group of about a dozen North American species that are so similar in their appearance, that it takes expert knowledge to tell them apart. Like most of its relatives, it has a long, slender body, protruding eyes, and a long, cylindrical tail. It is usually

mottled dark gray, with legs that vary from brown to red (pictured below is a rare, red-legged variant that may be a mimic of the red-legged Jordan's salamander). The mountain dusky salamander lives on land once it has matured, and spends daylight hours underground. At night, it emerges to feed on insects and other small animals. It is protected by a toxic skin secretion and, if threatened, it sometimes sheds its tail. During the breeding season, adults mate on land. The male stimulates his prospective partner by rubbing a pheromone onto her skin, and abrading the skin's surface with specialized teeth. The female deposits a cluster of 12–20 eggs in a cavity beneath a tree trunk or underground, guarding them until they hatch. The larvae develop in streams. Adults are particularly active after rain, but they spend the winter underground.

